

solace, high-profile godmen and women were seemingly indulging in acts that were not just unlawful but downright sinful.

It's been a rude awakening, not just for the faithful who flocked to their ashrams, but also for the local police, politicians and celebrities who gave them earthly protection. Till now, no one dared question their lifestyle: jet-setting around visiting their ashrams in India and abroad, producing expensive Swiss watches from thin air to present to their disciples who included the rich and powerful. After the shocking details about Madhavan surfaced, others have come forward to register scores of complaints against them. The state police, initially apprehensive about the connections in high places of the godmen, have since initiated investigations, conducted raids and arrested many. "We will book them all. We have launched a special drive to investigate the wealth amassed by these so-called spiritual leaders," says state Home Minister Kodyeri Balakrishnan.

The trigger for the special drive was an Interpol 'red corner' warrant issued through CBI for Madhavan following a complaint to the Dubai Police by Serafin Edwin, a Malayalee businesswoman based in the UAE. She said Madhavan had cheated her of about Rs 45 lakh. The 35-year-old godman who was running a high profile ashram in

Kochi, frequented by top politicians, police officials and film stars, was not arrested by the state police even after CBI issued a warrant many months ago.

After a media exposé on Madhavan, the police arrested him on May 13 and remanded him to custody. Three complaints of rape have been filed against the godman by three girls who are underaged. They have stated that they were forced into sexual relations with Madhavan and later were forced to appear in a pornographic video. The raid by the police on his house and bank lockers uncovered scores of pornographic CDs, documents detailing wealth and properties running into crores, stocks of ganja and even a leopard skin. Many politicians and police officials who appear on Madhavan's photo albums or his brochures as his friends, devotees or benefactors have quickly distanced themselves from him following the raid, saying they never knew his "actual self". A deputy superintendent of police has been since suspended for being too close to Madhavan.

However the most prominent spiritual leader who is being investigated now is Bishop K.P. Yohannan who heads an independent church called Believers Church and also runs the Asian wing of US-based Gospel for Asia, an evangelical organisation. Yohannan's Church owns a large number of properties, rubber



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